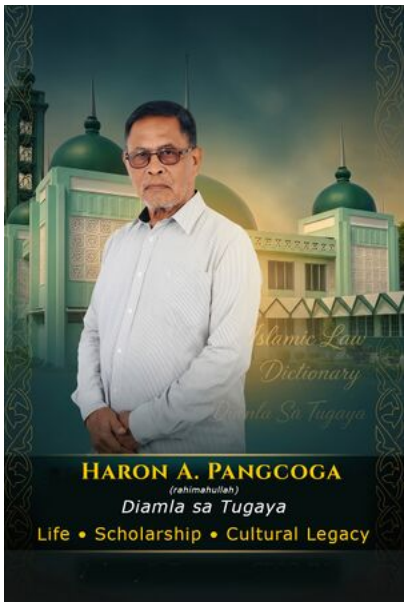
Haron A. Pangcoga

Haron A. Pangcoga (December 30, 1956 – February 16, 2019) was a Filipino Islamic legal scholar, educator, and traditional leader from Tugaya, Lanao del Sur who spent nearly four decades shaping how the Bangsamoro community understood and practiced Islamic law in the Philippines. He served as a professor and administrator at the Mindanao State University (MSU), most notably as Director of the Shari'ah Center and as the Director of MADARIS under the Department of Education, Culture, and Sports (DECS) of the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM). Beyond the academy, Pangcoga was enthroned in 2018 as the **Diamla Sa Tugaya**, one of the four principal traditional leaders of his home municipality, a title that recognized his lifelong work as a custodian of Maranao culture and custom. His crowning scholarly achievement, the *Islamic Law Dictionary*, was published posthumously in 2023 by Xavier University Press and stands as the first comprehensive reference of its kind in the Philippines. For those who knew him, Pangcoga's life embodied a rare kind of synthesis: the ability to hold tradition and modernity together without letting either one break.

Contents

1 Ancestral Lineage and Early Life
2 Education and Professional Formation
3 Career
  3.1 Early Teaching and International Exposure
  3.2 Faculty Career at MSU
  3.3 Director of MADARIS, DECS-ARMM (1992)
  3.4 Director of the Shari'ah Center, MSU (2015–2017)
4 Scholarly Contributions
  4.1 Reconciling Adat and Shari'ah
  4.2 The Islamic Law Dictionary (Posthumous, 2023)
5 Traditional Leadership: Diamla Sa Tugaya
6 Mentorship and Community Work
7 Legacy
8 Recognition and Public Presence
9 Death
10 Further Reading
11 See Also

Haron A. Pangcoga



Born	December 30, 1956 Tugaya, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Died	February 16, 2019 Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao
Education	Mindanao State University B.A. Islamic Studies (1977) M.P.A. (1981) M.A. Shari'ah (1988)
Profession	Professor, Legal Scholar, Administrator
Employer	MSU – King Faisal Center
Title	Diamla Sa Tugaya
Enthroned	February 24, 2018
Spouse	Hadja Hafsah "Norhaya" Manugangcar Zacaria
Children	10
Region	Bangsamoro

Ancestral Lineage and Early Life

Pangcoga was born on December 30, 1956, in Tugaya, Lanao del Sur, a municipality known throughout the Lanao region as the artisanal heart of the Maranao world. Tugaya is the place where the *Taritib and Igma* (the traditional order and consensus system of the Maranao) governs social life with a force almost equivalent to written law. Growing up there wasn't simply a matter of geography; it meant being raised within a living framework of custom, rank, and responsibility.

His family background placed him squarely within the upper tier of Maranao traditional leadership. He was a nephew of Dr. Salipada S. Tamano, a widely respected figure in the Bangsamoro educational sector who served as Regional Secretary of the DECS in the ARMM. His kinship network also included Ayonan "Datu sa Palao" Pangcoga, a former Vice Mayor of Tugaya, and his sister, Hadja Moshrifah "Iram" Pangcoga-Acop, who remained an active figure in community affairs. These connections were never just personal. They represented a web of influence that drew together modern administrative authority and traditional communal governance.

His marriage to **Hadja Hafsah "Norhaya" Manugangcar Zacaria** deepened those roots considerably. Norhaya came from the Sultanate of Tugaya lineage: her father was Sheikh Zacaria Moka Disomnong, a prominent business leader during the early years of Dansalan (now Marawi City), and her mother, Hadja Omensalam Tocalo Manugangcar Zacaria, carried the prestigious title of *Bae a Labi a Diamla Sa Tugaya.*<ref name="salsila">Salsila/Genealogical record of Sultan Mohammad Muid Zacaria of Tugaya. Tugaya Artefacts Blog. Retrieved March 11, 2026, from https://tugayaartefactsblog.wordpress.com/2014/02/25/salsilageneological-record-of-sultan-mohammad-muid-zacaria-of-tugaya/</ref> The Zacaria family belonged to the *Nine Maruhoms of Tugaya,* the founding lineages that have held sultanate positions across centuries of Maranao history.<ref name="salsila" /> Through this marriage, Pangcoga became formally anchored to the *Salsila* (genealogical records) of the Sultanate of Tugaya and took on the custodianship of the Amito Clan, a responsibility that would eventually lead to his enthronement.

Together, Pangcoga and Norhaya raised ten children: Mohammad (married to Mohairah Salbo Pamlian), Yusoph (married to Jalfah Salong Farhan), Zeenal Abdul (married to Faizah Bacaraman Matanog), Walid (married to Nor-Aisah Molan Lomodag), Rohaida (married to Abdul Mughnie Marohombsar Gunting), Mohammad Rasul (married to Omaimah Calauto Abdulazis), Alihassan (married to Hanifah Tamano Latiph), Rohanisa (married to Aleem Abdul Rauf Sampaco Mapunud), Omar (married to Jannairah Guinar Matanog), and Rohanifah Goldie. His son Walid Zacaria Pangcoga has since carried forward the family's documentary work, maintaining digital archives of the Salsila and the history of the Sultanate of Tugaya.<ref name="salsila" />

Education and Professional Formation

Pangcoga entered Mindanao State University (MSU) in the mid-1970s, a period of intense political and cultural awakening among Muslim students in the country. He earned his **Bachelor of Arts in Islamic Studies** in 1977, giving him a solid grounding in theology, Islamic history, and jurisprudence. But he wasn't content to stay in one lane. Recognizing that the Bangsamoro community needed leaders who could move between religious authority and state administration, he pursued a **Master in Public Administration** in 1981, followed by a **Master of Arts in Shari'ah** in 1988, the latter being a program that was at the forefront of reconciling the Philippine legal system with Shari'ah principles.

His academic formation didn't stop there. He completed 24 units toward a Doctor of Philosophy and three years of a Bachelor of Laws (LL.B.) at the MSU College of Law. The range of his study was intentional. He was building the capacity to speak fluently in the languages of both the *Ulama* (Islamic religious scholars) and the secular legal community.

On the professional certification front, his record was equally deliberate. He passed the Career Service Professional examination in 1977, the Shari'ah Bar Examinations administered by the Supreme Court of the Philippines in 1992, and the Board Examinations for Teachers under the Professional Regulation Commission (PRC) in 1998. This combination of administrative, legal, and pedagogical licensure was rare, and it gave him an unusual range of authority. At different points in his career, he could function as a government official, a Shari'ah counselor, and a classroom teacher, all with formal credentials to back each role.

Career

Early Teaching and International Exposure

Pangcoga's career began on the ground. He started as a teacher at Dansalan College in 1977 and moved on to teach at MSU-Tugaya in 1979. These years gave him a firsthand understanding of how education actually worked (and didn't work) in the Lanao countryside. A brief stint as an Administrative Manager in Saudi Arabia in 1982 broadened his perspective considerably. Living and working at the center of the Islamic world shaped his sense of what Shari'ah could look like when properly institutionalized, and that experience informed much of his reform work back home.

Faculty Career at MSU

Returning to the Philippines, Pangcoga joined the faculty of MSU – King Faisal Center for Islamic, Arabic, and Asian Studies (KFCIAAS), where he rose from Instructor to full Professor over the course of nearly four decades. The progression was steady and hard-earned. He taught courses in Muslim Personal Law, Islamic jurisprudence, and Shari'ah practice, becoming one of the institution's most recognized voices on the intersection of religion and law.

Director of MADARIS, DECS-ARMM (1992)

One of the defining chapters of Pangcoga's career came when he served as Director of MADARIS for the DECS-ARMM. At the time, the *Madrasah* (Islamic school) system in the Philippines was largely informal. It operated on community goodwill, with *Ustads* (male religious teachers) and *Ustadjas* (female religious teachers) receiving little to no compensation from the state and working without any recognized professional standing.

Pangcoga changed that. In 1992, he proposed and implemented a licensure examination system for Madrasah teachers. The goal was straightforward: bring Islamic education into the formal structure of the Department of Education so that religious teachers could receive funded positions, regular salaries, and the professional recognition they had long been denied. This was a bold move at the time. It required convincing both the government bureaucracy and the traditional religious community that professionalization was not a threat to faith but a support for it.

The reform worked. Thousands of teachers across the ARMM gained formally recognized positions as a direct result of this initiative, and it laid the institutional groundwork for what would eventually become the nationwide **ALIVE Program** (Arabic Language and Islamic Values Education) of the Department of Education.<ref name="pia">Philippine Information Agency. (n.d.). Muslims affirm PH's first Islamic law dictionary banners justice and compassion. Retrieved from https://pia.gov.ph/news/muslims-affirm-phs-first-islamic-law-dictionary-banners-justice-compassion/</ref>

Director of the Shari'ah Center, MSU (2015–2017)

Pangcoga's most focused period of institutional reform at the university came during his tenure as **Director of the Shari'ah Center** from 2015 to 2017. He became the primary architect of the review programs for the Shari'ah Bar Examinations, a national examination administered by the Supreme Court of the Philippines. He understood clearly that the scarcity of qualified Shari'ah counselors was a serious bottleneck in the delivery of justice for Muslims. Too few people were passing the bar, too few law schools were preparing graduates to work within Presidential Decree 1083 (the Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines), and the communities that needed legal representation the most were being left without it.

His work at the Shari'ah Center addressed this directly. He developed structured review materials, coordinated legal training programs, and mentored the next generation of Shari'ah practitioners who would go on to serve in Shari'ah courts across the ARMM and later the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM).

Scholarly Contributions

Reconciling Adat and Shari'ah

If there is one intellectual question that anchored all of Pangcoga's scholarly work, it's this: how do you harmonize the divine principles of Shari'ah with the ancient *Adat* (customary law) of the Maranao people and the statutory law of the Philippines? He didn't treat these as competing forces. He treated them as layers of a single living legal tradition that needed careful documentation and thoughtful reconciliation.

His 1992 paper, *Some Un-Islamic Provisions of Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines*, was a direct and critical engagement with that tension. He argued that for Shari'ah to serve Muslims effectively in the Philippines, the Code had to be honest about where it diverged from classical Islamic jurisprudence, and those gaps needed to be addressed rather than papered over.

In 2015, he produced *Survey of the Customary Law of the Bangsa Moro*, an ethnographic and legal map of *Adat* as practiced across Bangsamoro communities. The work explored the *Maranao Taritib,* the intricate system of protocols and genealogical lineages that governs disputes, marriages, and communal alliances among the Maranao. His unpublished manuscripts, *A Reviewer in Islamic Criminal Law and Shari'ah* and *Shari'ah and the Local Adat: A Comparative Study of Their Differences,* remain significant resources for researchers working on legal pluralism in the Philippines.

The Islamic Law Dictionary (Posthumous, 2023)

The most consequential single work Pangcoga left behind is the ***Islamic Law Dictionary***, published by Xavier University Press in 2023, four years after his death.<ref name="xu">Xavier University Press Catalogue, October 2023. Retrieved via Scribd, March 11, 2026, from https://www.scribd.com/document/705866468/XU-Press-Catalogue-October-2023</ref> It is the first comprehensive reference of its kind in the Philippines, providing standardized Arabic and English definitions for legal terms used in Shari'ah courts and in the study of *Adat.*<ref name="xu2">XU Press – Published Titles 2018–2023. Retrieved via Scribd, March 11, 2026, from https://www.scribd.com/document/705865917/XU-Press-Published-Titles-2018-2023</ref>

The Philippine Information Agency (PIA) and Muslim legal advocates described the dictionary as a milestone for justice and compassion in the Philippines.<ref name="pia" /> The reasons aren't hard to see. In Shari'ah courts, terminology matters enormously. When a judge, a counselor, and a litigant are working from different

understandings of the same Arabic legal term, the result is confusion at best and injustice at worst. The dictionary standardizes that language, giving practitioners a shared foundation to work from.<ref name="pia" />

> "A milestone for justice and compassion," wrote advocates in the Philippine Muslim community upon the dictionary's release, noting that it demystifies Shari'ah as a system built on benevolence and humanity rather than the harsh interpretations often found in mainstream public discourse.

The book was launched in the context of post-Marawi Siege recovery, which gave it added resonance. Marawi City was still rebuilding, and the dictionary was received not just as a legal tool but as a contribution to the broader intellectual recovery of a community that had been through a devastating ordeal. It was Pangcoga's way of saying, in print and for the record, that the laws and traditions of the Bangsamoro had a place in the national story of the Philippines.<ref name="pia" />

Traditional Leadership: Diamla Sa Tugaya

On February 24, 2018, Professor Haron A. Pangcoga was formally enthroned as the **Diamla Sa Tugaya**.<ref name="sultan">Mohammad Muid Zacaria enthroned as Sultan of Tugaya. Tugaya Artefacts Blog. Retrieved March 11, 2026, from https://tugayaartefactsblog.wordpress.com/2014/02/25/mohammad-muid-zacaria-enthroned-as-sultan-of-tugaya/comment-page-1/</ref> In the Maranao *Taritib*, the Diamla is one of four principal traditional pillars of the community, alongside the Sultan, the Cabugatan, and the Rajamuda. The title belongs specifically to the AMITO Clan, making Pangcoga's enthronement both a recognition of personal achievement and a fulfillment of genealogical responsibility.

As Diamla, his most visible public mission was to transform Tugaya into what he called the "Center for Muslim Culture and the Arts." He was deeply concerned that the traditional crafts of Tugaya, including brass casting, woodcarving (*Okir*), and silver smithing, were quietly disappearing as younger generations moved toward urban employment and as international trade undercut local artisans economically. He devoted significant energy to encouraging Tugaya craftspeople to raise the quality of their work and to find sustainable markets for their products.

His advocacy found national reach through Senator Loren Legarda's cultural programs *Dayaw* and *Buhay na Buhay,* where he appeared as a spokesperson for Maranao artistry.<ref name="dayaw">Legarda, L. (n.d.). Dayaw Season 2: The Art of the Vessel – Maranao, Tugaya. Facebook video. Retrieved from https://m.facebook.com/lorenlegarda/videos/dayaw-season-2-the-art-of-the-vessel-maranao-tugaya/10154869275988891/</ref> On these platforms, he made a point that was both practical and philosophical: preserving traditional crafts wasn't just about keeping old techniques alive. It was a form of economic empowerment, a way to maintain the *decency and security* of the community, and a statement that the Maranao identity was worth protecting on its own terms.

Mentorship and Community Work

Outside his formal roles, Pangcoga was the kind of person students and younger colleagues genuinely sought out. He was a founding father of the **first Muslim Toastmaster Club** at MSU-Marawi, believing that public speaking and leadership skills were essential tools for Muslim youth navigating both traditional community life and modern professional environments. He was also an active member of the **Beta Sigma fraternity** of Marawi and served as an advisor to the **Olympiads Tugayanians,** a group that encouraged youth from Tugaya to compete and excel beyond their hometown.

These initiatives reflected a conviction that ran throughout his career: the Bangsamoro community could only thrive if its young people were equipped to engage confidently with the wider world, and that confidence had to be built at home.

Legacy

Professor Pangcoga's legacy works on three levels that build on each other.

At the level of **knowledge**, he moved Shari'ah in the Philippines from the realm of oral tradition and scattered manuscripts toward a codified, accessible academic discipline. The *Islamic Law Dictionary* is the clearest evidence of this, but it's the culmination of decades of writing, teaching, and institutional work that made the dictionary possible.

At the level of **profession**, his Madrasah licensure reform in the 1990s turned Islamic teaching from an informal religious service into a recognized career. Thousands of Ustads and Ustadjas across the ARMM gained economic security and professional standing because of that decision. The ALIVE Program now operating in public schools nationwide carries that reform forward.

At the level of **culture**, his work as Diamla used the weight of traditional leadership to reframe Maranao craftsmanship as a serious national heritage asset, not a regional curiosity. By taking that argument to national television and into formal advocacy, he helped ensure that the arts of Tugaya would continue to be seen as part of the Filipino story.

His own words, shared in his final speeches, expressed what he understood his life's work to be:

> He wished to be "remembered in books," not out of personal vanity, but from a deep conviction that for a marginalized culture, the written word is the most durable shield against erasure, and that the intellectual contributions of the Bangsamoro deserved recognition as potent elements in transitioning to a better society.

Recognition and Public Presence

Pangcoga's recognition came in different forms across his career. Within MSU-KFCIAAS, he was acknowledged as one of the most authoritative voices on Muslim Personal Law and Shari'ah practice in the Philippines. His appointment as Director of the Shari'ah Center reflected the university's confidence in his ability to shape the professional formation of the next generation of Shari'ah practitioners.

On the national stage, his appearances on Senator Loren Legarda's cultural programs brought Tugaya's heritage and his advocacy for Maranao arts to a broad Filipino audience. The posthumous reception of his *Islamic Law Dictionary* by the Philippine Information Agency and Muslim legal advocates further cemented his standing as a contributor to the country's legal and cultural heritage.<ref name="pia" />

His enthronement as Diamla Sa Tugaya in 2018 was itself a public recognition by his own community of everything he had built over a lifetime.

Death

Professor Haron A. Pangcoga died on **February 16, 2019**, in the Philippines. He was 62 years old. He passed away with the manuscript of his *Islamic Law Dictionary* completed but not yet published, a reminder that some of the most important work a person does outlives them. The book would appear four years later, in 2023, through Xavier University Press, and the community he served would finally have the reference he had prepared for them.

His death came just under a year after his enthronement as Diamla Sa Tugaya, at a point when he had never been more fully himself: scholar, traditional leader, cultural advocate, and teacher, all at once.

Further Reading

- Pangcoga, H. A. (1992). *Some Un-Islamic Provisions of Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines.* Marawi City: Mindanao State University.
- Pangcoga, H. A. (2015). *Survey of the Customary Law of the Bangsa Moro.* Marawi City: Mindanao State University.
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- Tamano, A. S. (2026). *The Diamla's Enduring Legacy: The Life, Scholarship, and Cultural Significance of Professor Haron A. Pangcoga.* Bangsamoro Digital Ecosystem.
- Zacaria, W. (n.d.). Salsila/Genealogical Record of Sultan Mohammad Muid Zacaria of Tugaya. Tugaya Artefacts Blog. https://tugayaartefactsblog.wordpress.com

See Also

- Mindanao State University
- King Faisal Center for Islamic, Arabic, and Asian Studies
- Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines
- Shari'ah Bar Examinations (Philippines)
- Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Maranao people
- Tugaya, Lanao del Sur
- ALIVE Program
- Madrasah education in the Philippines
- Sultanate of Tugaya
- Okir

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